

↓ FINANCIAL CRAMMING

- If you work for a company that offers a flexible benefits plan, evaluate your options carefully. If you're single without any dependents, for instance, it probably makes sense to skip the life insurance offered by your employer and opt instead for better health insurance or more disability coverage.
- Don't go without health insurance, even if you're healthy. To find affordable coverage, see if there's a group you can join, such as a trade association or religious organization, that gives you access to a group policy. If you're between jobs, buy low-cost temporary coverage. (For general tips on shopping for an individual policy, see chapter 8.)
- For car insurance, check online with companies that sell directly to consumers. And think twice before allowing a friend to drive your car. If there's an accident, *your* insurance record will be tainted, not your friend's.
- Get disability insurance to protect yourself in case you can't work due to injury or illness. Ideally, you should have coverage that would pay you 60% to 70% of your income if you become disabled. (For advice on reducing the cost of your coverage, see chapter 8.)
- Buy renters insurance if you rent a house or an apartment. It protects your possessions if they're ruined in a fire or stolen, and it also offers you some liability coverage inside and away from your home.
- If you have kids or anyone else dependent on your income, buy term life insurance for yourself and write up a will. If you don't have dependents, you probably don't need any life insurance at all, but you probably still need a will.